using a character whose sound is well known and generally in use already.

Another stage in the development of the language led to a major increase in vocabulary through the use of two characters instead of one to constitute a word. This also enabled much greater precision and finer shades of meaning in the use of the language, when compared to other languages. Translations are rarely able to capture the more subtle nuances which Chinese is able to convey. Perhaps the use of ‘sandhi’, or combinations, in Sanskrit may be a parallel phenomenon.

Spoken Chinese introduces another challenge to a non-native speaker. Modern spoken Chinese is based on the Beijing dialect, which is known as Mandarin. Mandarin has four intonations – rising, flat, descending and curved. The same word, using different tones, conveys widely differing meanings. For example, take the word ‘Ma’, which with a rising tone may mean hemp; with a descending tone abuse; with a flat tone mother; and with a curved tone horse. It is easy to see how amenable the language is to creating ambiguity and punning, and these are artfully used in political discourse and debate.

Although the Chinese script may appear somewhat strange and complicated to Indians used to phonetic languages based on an alphabet, some of the conceptions conveyed by the characters are familiar. For example, the commonly used term *‘ni hao’* , which is a form of polite greeting, means ‘are you well?’ The character for *‘hao’* is a woman holding a child, which is meant to convey a sense of well-being, which would be a familiar notion to Indians. The same ideogram with the character with a roof added over it is meant to convey peace or *‘an’* , that is, a woman and child with a roof over their heads.

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How has Chinese adapted to modern scientific and technical terms? Japanese, for example, has used its phonetic script (based, incidentally, on the Sanskrit syllabary of *ka, kha, ga* . . .) to incorporate foreign words rather than translate them into Japanese. Thus, computer becomes compotu, hotel becomes hoteru and so on. The Chinese meticulously translate every new